

D270

Composition: Successful Self-Expression

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

A student interested in climate change has two weeks and a 1,500-word limit for a research paper. She found 40 articles in the library database in a single evening. Which research question is best?

- A. What is climate change?
- B. Why is climate change the only issue that matters today?
- C. Which of the 40 articles is the most recent?
- D. How have heat-related emergency room visits in Phoenix changed since 2010?

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

A researcher studying 1930s labor strikes finds a union member's diary from 1937, a 2015 history book about the strikes, and a documentary released in 1998. The library keeps the diary in climate-controlled storage. Which is a primary source?

- A. The 2015 history book.
- B. None, because only government documents count as primary.
- C. The 1998 documentary.
- D. The 1937 diary.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which is a secondary source for a paper on a 2021 city council vote?

- A. A news analysis published a month later explaining why the vote passed.
- B. A video recording of the council session.
- C. An email a council member sent the night of the vote.
- D. The official minutes of the meeting.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A student finds an article on the health risks of vaping. It was written by a physician in 2024 and cites several studies, but it is posted on the website of a company that sells e-cigarettes. The page is well designed and has 12,000 shares. What is the main credibility concern?

- A. Authority: the author lacks expertise.
- B. Purpose and bias: the publisher has a financial stake in the conclusion.
- C. Currency: the information is out of date.
- D. None, because 12,000 shares show readers trust it.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

An instructor requires three peer-reviewed sources. A student finds a magazine article with glossy photos, an interview with a professor, and 2 million readers, and a journal article that independent experts reviewed before publication, with a methods section and reference list. The journal is published quarterly. Which should count?

- A. The magazine article, because it quotes a professor.
- B. Neither, since a quarterly journal is too slow to be current.
- C. The journal article.
- D. Both, since both were published.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

A writer rewords a paragraph from a government report into her own words and sentence structure. The report is 80 pages long and was posted as a PDF. What must she do?

- A. Cite the report, even though the wording is her own.
- B. Nothing, because paraphrases never need a citation.
- C. Put the paraphrase in quotation marks.
- D. List all 80 pages in her citation.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A writer copies a sentence word for word from a source and adds an in-text citation but no quotation marks. What is the problem?

- A. She should delete the citation.
- B. Exact wording needs quotation marks; without them it is still plagiarism.
- C. There is no problem, because the citation covers it.
- D. Quoting is never allowed in academic writing.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8.

In a paper on shipping for an operations course, a student notes that the Pacific is the largest ocean, that a 2023 industry survey found 62 percent of shippers faced port delays, and that her uncle works at a port. Her paper is due Friday. Which statement requires a citation?

- A. The 2023 survey finding that 62 percent of shippers faced delays.
- B. None of them, since short papers do not need citations.
- C. That her uncle works at a port.
- D. That the Pacific is the largest ocean.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which statement can usually be written without a citation because it is common knowledge?

- A. One economist argues that remote work lowers wages over time.
- B. A 2022 national survey found 41 percent of adults work remotely at least one day a week.
- C. The county unemployment rate was 4.1 percent last March.
- D. The United States declared independence in 1776.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A student quotes directly from page 14 of a 2021 article by Rivera in a journal with a 30-person editorial board. APA 7 is required. Which in-text citation is correct?

- A. (Rivera 14)
- B. (Rivera, 2021, p. 30)
- C. (Rivera, 2021, p. 14)
- D. (Rivera, 2021)

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

An APA paper includes the in-text citation (Nguyen & Park, 2019). Where does a reader find the full source details?

- A.** On a Works Cited page listing only quoted sources.
- B.** In a footnote at the bottom of the page.
- C.** In the reference list at the end, alphabetized under Nguyen.
- D.** In the reference list, alphabetized under Park.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A project coordinator is writing to partners in Brazil, Germany, and India. Her draft says: Let's touch base on 04/05 and hit the ground running. She has worked at the company for nine years and writes most of its newsletters. Which revision best suits this audience?

- A.** Let's meet on 04/05 to begin the project.
- B.** Let's meet on 5 April 2026 at 14:00 UTC to begin the project.
- C.** Let's touch base on April 5 and hit the ground running.
- D.** Use formal legal language so there is no chance of misunderstanding.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

A student interested in climate change has two weeks and a 1,500-word limit for a research paper. ~~She found 40 articles in the library database in a single evening.~~ Which research question is best?

Target word: best research question **Decides:** Two weeks and 1,500 words need a focused question.

A	Dropped element	Too broad and definitional; drops the need for focus.
B	Absolute language	Built on an absolute claim that cannot be supported.
C	Camouflage	The number of articles found does not make a research question.
D	Correct	Focused, researchable in scope, and open to analysis.

2. Answer D Concept 2

A researcher studying 1930s labor strikes finds a union member's diary from 1937, a 2015 history book about the strikes, and a documentary released in 1998. ~~The library keeps the diary in climate-controlled storage.~~ Which is a primary source?

Target word: pick the primary source **Decides:** Firsthand account from the time.

A	Confusion set	Later analysis: secondary.
B	Absolute language	Personal records are primary sources too.
C	Adjacent category	A later interpretation, even if it uses old footage.
D	Correct	Firsthand evidence created during the events.

3. Answer A Concept 2 · transfer

Which is a secondary source for a paper on a 2021 city council vote?

Target word: pick the secondary source — reverse **Decides:** Later interpretation of the vote.

A	Correct	Interprets the event after the fact.
B	Confusion set	Raw record of the event: primary.
C	Adjacent category	A firsthand document from a participant: primary.
D	Inverted operation	A record made at the event: primary.

4. Answer B Concept 3

A student finds an article on the health risks of vaping. It was written by a physician in 2024 and cites several studies, but it is posted on the website of a company that sells e-cigarettes. ~~The page is well designed and has 12,000 shares.~~ What is the main credibility concern?

Target word: main credibility problem **Decides:** The publisher profits from the conclusion.

A	Dropped element	Drops the fact that the author is a physician.
B	Correct	Author, date, and citations are fine; the sponsor's interest is the red flag.
C	Confusion set	2024 is recent.
D	Camouflage	Popularity and design do not establish credibility.

5. Answer C Concept 4

An instructor requires three peer-reviewed sources. A student finds a magazine article with glossy photos, an interview with a professor, ~~and 2 million readers~~, and a journal article that independent experts reviewed before publication, with a methods section and reference list. ~~The journal is published quarterly.~~ Which should count?

Target word: which counts as peer-reviewed **Decides:** Reviewed by independent experts before publication.

A	Adjacent category	Quoting an expert does not make a source peer-reviewed.
B	Camouflage	Publishing schedule does not decide peer-review status.
C	Correct	Expert review before publication plus methods and references mark peer review.
D	Confusion set	Publication alone is not peer review.

6. Answer A Concept 5

A writer rewords a paragraph from a government report into her own words and sentence structure. ~~The report is 80 pages long and was posted as a PDF.~~ What must she do?

Target word: citation rule for a paraphrase **Decides:** The ideas still come from the source.

A	Correct	Paraphrased ideas still need credit.
B	Absolute language	Borrowed ideas always need a citation.
C	Adjacent category	Quotation marks are for exact wording.
D	Camouflage	Report length does not decide the rule.

7. Answer B Concept 5 · transfer

A writer copies a sentence word for word from a source and adds an in-text citation but no quotation marks. What is the problem?

Target word: flaw in a cited but unquoted copy — reverse case **Decides:** Exact wording requires quotation marks.

A	Inverted operation	Makes the problem worse.
B	Correct	The citation credits the idea, but the marks show the words are not hers.
C	Dropped element	Drops the quotation-mark requirement.
D	Absolute language	Quotations are allowed when marked and cited.

8. Answer A Concept 6

In a paper on shipping for an operations course, a student notes that the Pacific is the largest ocean, that a 2023 industry survey found 62 percent of shippers faced port delays, and that her uncle works at a port. ~~Her paper is due Friday.~~ Which statement requires a citation?

Target word: which needs a citation **Decides:** A specific statistic from a survey.

A	Correct	Specific data from a source must be cited.
B	Absolute language	Length does not remove the need to cite.
C	Confusion set	Personal knowledge is not from a source.
D	Inverted operation	Common knowledge; no citation needed.

9. Answer D Concept 6 · transfer

Which statement can usually be written without a citation because it is common knowledge?

Target word: pick the no-citation fact — reverse **Decides:** Widely known and easily checked.

A	Confusion set	Someone else's argument needs credit.
B	Inverted operation	Specific survey data needs a citation.
C	Adjacent category	A specific local statistic, not common knowledge.
D	Correct	Widely known and found in many general sources.

10. Answer C Concept 7

A student quotes directly from page 14 of a 2021 article by Rivera ~~in a journal with a 30-person editorial board~~. APA 7 is required. Which in-text citation is correct?

Target word: correct APA quote citation **Decides:** Direct quote needs author, year, and page.

A	Confusion set	That is MLA style.
B	Wrong stem number	Uses the editorial-board size instead of the page.
C	Correct	APA format for a direct quote.
D	Dropped element	Leaves out the page number a quote requires.

11. Answer C Concept 7 · transfer

An APA paper includes the in-text citation (Nguyen & Park, 2019). Where does a reader find the full source details?

Target word: where the full entry lives — reverse **Decides:** APA reference list, alphabetized by first author.

A	Adjacent category	Works Cited is MLA, and it lists all cited sources.
B	Confusion set	Footnotes belong to Chicago notes style.
C	Correct	APA sorts by first author's surname.
D	Inverted operation	Uses the second author instead of the first.

12. Answer B Concept 8

A project coordinator is writing to partners in Brazil, Germany, and India. Her draft says: Let's touch base on 04/05 and hit the ground running. ~~She has worked at the company for nine years and writes most of its newsletters.~~ Which revision best suits this audience?

Target word: best cross-cultural revision **Decides:** Remove idioms and write the date unambiguously.

A	Adjacent category	Drops idioms but 04/05 can mean April 5 or May 4.
B	Correct	Literal wording, clear date and time zone.
C	Dropped element	Fixes the date but keeps the idioms.
D	Absolute language	Legal jargon adds difficulty, and no wording removes all risk.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owled.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	5	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	1	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	7	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	5	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	6	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	8	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	4	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Narrowing a research question	A good research question is focused, researchable in the time and length allowed, and open to analysis rather than a yes/no or dictionary answer.	Picking the broadest, most important-sounding question.	A word limit or deadline plus several candidate questions.
2	Primary vs. secondary sources	A primary source is firsthand evidence from the time or person studied; a secondary source analyzes or interprets primary sources later.	Calling anything old, or anything with original clips, primary.	Diaries, minutes, data, and recordings vs. books and articles about them.
3	Judging source credibility	Check currency, relevance, authority, accuracy, and purpose; a source that profits from its conclusion has a bias problem even if other signs look good.	Trusting design, popularity, or credentials alone.	A publisher with a stake in the answer.
4	Scholarly vs. popular	Peer-reviewed sources are checked by independent experts before publication and include methods and references.	Counting a magazine as scholarly because it quotes an expert.	"Peer-reviewed" in an assignment requirement.
5	Paraphrase and quotation	Paraphrases need a citation; exact wording needs quotation marks and a citation.	Thinking rewording removes the need to cite, or that a citation covers unquoted copying.	"In her own words" or "word for word."
6	Common knowledge	Widely known, easily checked facts need no citation; specific statistics, studies, and others' ideas do.	Leaving specific numbers uncited because they seem factual.	A stem mixing general facts with a specific survey figure.
7	APA in-text citations	APA uses (Author, Year) and adds a page number for direct quotations; full details go in the alphabetical reference list.	Using MLA or footnote formats, or leaving out the page for a quote.	"Quotes directly" and "APA."
8	Writing for cross-cultural readers	Use plain, literal language, avoid idioms and slang, and write dates and times unambiguously.	Keeping friendly idioms or numeric dates that read differently abroad.	An international audience and phrases like "touch base" or dates like 04/05.

Course scope (public description): Welcome to Composition: Successful Self-Expression! In this course, you will focus on four main topics: professional writing for a cross-cultural audience, narrowing research topics and questions, researching for content to support a topic, and referencing research sources. Each section includes learning opportunities through readings, videos, audio, and other relevant resources. Assessment activities with feedback also provide opportunities to check your learning, practice, and show how well you understand course content. Because the course is self-paced, you may move through the material as quickly or as slowly as you need to gain proficiency in the seven competencies that will be covered in the final assessment. If you have no prior knowledge or experience, you can expect to spend 30-40 hours on the course content. You will demonstrate competency through a performance assessment. There is no prerequisite for this course and there is no specific technical knowledge needed.